



Heritage Topic Paper

July 2023



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Background

Coventry grew to become one of the most important cities in England during the Middle Ages due to its booming cloth and textiles trade. The city was noted for its part in the English Civil War, and later became an important industrial city during the 19th and 20th centuries, becoming the centre of the British bicycle and later motor industry. The devastating Blitz in 1940 destroyed much of the city centre and saw its rebuilding during the 1950s and 60s. The motor industry slumped during the 1970s and 80s, and Coventry saw high unemployment. However, in the new millennium the city, along with many others saw significant urban renaissance and in 2017 it was announced that the city had been awarded the title of 2021 UK City of Culture.

There are over 400 statutorily Listed Buildings, over 280 Locally Listed Buildings; 18 Conservation Areas; 20 Scheduled Monuments; and 3 Registered Gardens in the city. This constitutes a rich and visible heritage, which needs to be protected, enhanced and interpreted. In many cases, this obvious backbone of the historic environment contributes significantly to a sense of place, most prominently in the three cathedrals area of the city centre. On a smaller scale, Allesley Village and Ivy Farm Lane derive their character principally from groupings of statutory and locally listed buildings. The long and grand tree-lined approach to the city along the Kenilworth Road and Joseph Paxton's London Road Cemetery, demonstrate the contribution that nationally important historic landscapes make to the city.

During the 1950 – 1960's, the City Architects Office, led by Donald Gibson and his successor Arthur Ling, produced and intensely urban architecture in Coventry incorporating Swedish and Festival of Britain influences, and promoting social equality through planned public places, with examples of the high-quality design extended to municipal housing and civic buildings. In 2016 and in partnership with Historic England 'Coventry; The making of a modern city 1939 – 73' was published, it celebrates Coventry's Post War Architecture, recognising its national significance with many of the buildings within the Upper Precinct and Lower Precinct becoming listed.

Plans, Policies and Programmes

National Policy: The Town and Country Planning Act 1990; the Planning (Listed Building and Conservation Areas Act) 1990 and the National Planning Policy Framework 2021.

Primary legislation for the Historic Environment is called the 'Town and Country Planning Act 1990' which provides specific protection for buildings and areas of special architectural or historic interest.

Any decisions relating to listed buildings and their settings and conservation areas must address the statutory considerations of the Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990 (see sections 16, 66 and 72).

Section 16 of the NPPF deals with 'conserving and enhancing the historic environment' the objective of this policy framework is sustainability: meeting the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.

The following paragraphs within Section 16 of the National Planning Policy Framework (NPPF) set out the local authorities statutory requirements when putting together a local plan:

190. *Plans should set out a positive strategy for the conservation and enjoyment of the historic environment, including heritage assets most at risk through neglect, decay or other threats. This strategy should take into account:*
- (a) the desirability of sustaining and enhancing the significance of heritage assets, and putting them to viable uses consistent with their conservation;*
 - (b) the wider social, cultural, economic and environmental benefits that conservation of the historic environment can bring;*
 - (c) the desirability of new development making a positive contribution to local character and distinctiveness; and*
 - (d) opportunities to draw on the contribution made by the historic environment to the character of a place.*
191. *When considering the designation of conservation areas, local planning authorities should ensure that an area justifies such status because of its special architectural or historic interest, and that the concept of conservation is not devalued through the designation of areas that lack special interest.*
195. *Local planning authorities should identify and assess the particular significance of any heritage asset that may be affected by a proposal (including by development affecting the setting of a heritage asset) taking account of the available evidence and any necessary expertise. They should take this into account when considering the impact of a proposal on a heritage asset, to avoid or minimise any conflict between the heritage asset's conservation and any aspect of the proposal.*

Local Policy: Coventry City Council Local Plan 2011-2031

In order to protect the and enhance the historic environment, alongside national policy the City council primarily refers to local plan policies; HE1, HE2, HE3 & CC2 of Coventry City Centre Area Action Plan (AAP) – 2011-2031 which seek to conserve and enhance Coventry's historic environment, policy HE1 states:

Policy HE1 Conservation Areas

1. *The areas listed below have been designated as Conservation Areas under Section 69 of the Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990 and are detailed on the Policies Map:*
 - a. Allesley*
 - b. Chapelfields*
 - c. Coventry Canal*
 - d. Far Gosford Street*
 - e. Greyfriars Green*
 - f. Hawkesbury Junction*

- g. High Street*
- h. Hill Top*
- i. Ivy Farm Lane*
- j. Kenilworth Road*
- k. Lady Herbert's Garden and The Burges*
- l. London Road*
- m. Naul's Mill*
- n. Spon End*
- o. Spon Street*
- p. Stoke Green*

2. *The following areas are proposed for designation as Conservation Areas:*

- a. Earlsdon*
- b. Brownshill Green*

The exact boundaries will be determined by the production of Conservation Area Appraisals and Management Plans following public consultation.

3. *Conservation Area Appraisals and Management Plans will be produced for all of the Conservation Areas to guide their preservation and enhancement. All development proposals within Conservation Areas will be determined in accordance with this Plan and the appropriate Appraisal and Management*

Policy HE2: Conservation and Heritage Assets

1. *In order to help sustain the historic character, sense of place, environmental quality and local distinctiveness of Coventry, development proposals will be supported where they conserve and, where appropriate, enhance those aspects of the historic environment which are recognised as being of special historic, archaeological, architectural, artistic, landscape or townscape significance. These Heritage Assets include:*

- a. Listed Buildings and Locally Listed buildings;*
- b. Conservation Areas;*
- c. Scheduled Ancient Monuments and Archaeological sites;*
- d. Registered Parks and Gardens; and*
- e. Other places, spaces, structures and features which may not be formally designated but are recognised as significant elements of Coventry's heritage and are positively identified on the Coventry Historic Environment Record.*

2. *Proposals likely to affect the significance of a heritage asset or its setting should demonstrate an understanding of such significance using currently available evidence.*
3. *Development proposals involving heritage assets in general and listed buildings in particular, should acknowledge the significance of the existing building and the area by means of their siting, massing, form, scale, materials and detail.*
4. *The sympathetic and creative re-use of heritage assets will be encouraged, especially for heritage that is considered to be at risk, so long as it is not damaging to the significance of the heritage asset. The embodied energy present in historic buildings contributes to sustainability.*
5. *The Council will use its statutory powers to secure the preservation of buildings and other heritage assets that are deemed to be at risk by the national and local heritage at risk registers.*
6. *Demolition or destruction of heritage assets will be resisted; proposals to demolish a heritage asset will therefore need substantial justification. The greater the damage to the significance of the asset, the greater the justification required and the public benefit needed to outweigh such damage.*
7. *All proposals should aim to sustain and reinforce the special character and conserve the following distinctive historic elements of Coventry:*
 - a. *The surviving buildings, defences and street plan of the medieval city centre and its suburbs;*
 - b. *The surviving pre-industrial settlements and landscape features which have been subsumed by the expansion of the city such as Walsgrave, Canley, Binley, Brownhill Green, Coundon Green, Little Heath (Spring Road), Stivichall Croft and Lower Eastern Green (at Dial House Lane);*
 - c. *The wider Arden rural environment on the fringe of the city comprising field-systems, ancient woodlands and commons which developed over centuries; interspersed with a mix of settlements, farmsteads and smallholdings;*
 - d. *Buildings associated with the city's industrial heritage; ribbon weaving, watch making, cycle making, motor car manufacturing, brick making, coal mining, synthetic textiles, munitions, aeronautical engineering, canals and railways;*
 - e. *The Victorian and Edwardian suburbs such as Earlsdon and Stoke;*
 - f. *Designed landscapes, including historic parks and gardens (both registered and locally listed), historic cemeteries, churchyards and public parks;*
 - g. *The significant elements of Coventry's ground-breaking post-war reconstruction including its plan, built form, public art works and public spaces; and*
 - h. *Archaeological remains of all periods from the earliest Prehistoric human habitation to the modern industrial period.*
8. *Where material change to a heritage asset has been agreed, recording and interpretation should be undertaken to document and understand the asset's archaeological, architectural or*

historic significance. The scope of the recording should be proportionate to the asset's significance and the impact of the development on the asset. The information and understanding gained should be made publicly available, as a minimum through the Coventry Historic Environment Record.

Policy HE3 Heritage Park – Charterhouse

- 1. Proposals for a City Heritage Park in the grounds of the Charterhouse and London Road cemetery will be supported along with measures to improve linkages to the area along the River Sherbourne (between Charterhouse and Far Gosford Street), the former Coventry loop railway line and across the London Road. Proposals that are detrimental to the establishment of the heritage park and the improvement of linkages will be resisted.*
- 2. Land at Blue Coat School is to be removed from the Green Belt in accordance with policy GB1 to support the expansion of school facilities on condition that the existing school car park is removed from the area of the Charterhouse Scheduled Ancient Monument. In addition, the expansion of the school should also support the appropriate relocation of the all-weather sports facilities and playground areas to secure the enhancement of the riverside area. This should facilitate the re-naturalisation of the area in an appropriate way in order to enhance the setting of the Charterhouse, its precinct and the Heritage Park as a whole.*
- 3. The creation of the Heritage Park and expansion of Blue Coat School should be guided by a comprehensive Master plan, which reflects the policies of this Plan.*

Coventry City Centre Area Action Plan (AAP) – 2011-2031

Policy CC2: Enhancement of Heritage Assets

- a) All development within, or affecting the setting of, a Conservation Area (as highlighted in Figure 2) shall preserve or enhance its character and appearance and adhere to the policies of the relevant Conservation Area Appraisal and Management Plan.*
- b) All development relating to or in close proximity to heritage assets such as statutory and locally listed buildings, Scheduled Monuments, public artwork and non-designated heritage assets (Figure 2) shall be undertaken sympathetically to those heritage assets and seek to preserve or enhance their setting.*
- c) New developments which include or take place adjacent to the remaining sections of the medieval City Wall must enhance the setting of the wall and to incorporate it into the landscape design. Where appropriate the Council will seek contributions from developers for the repair and maintenance of the wall. Archaeological investigations must be undertaken where development is proposed on the former site of the City Wall. Opportunities to reflect the line of the medieval Wall should also be incorporated into such developments.*

- d) *New developments must retain and where possible re-instate the street plan of the medieval city where it can contribute to accessibility, local character and distinctiveness.*
- e) *Within Archaeological Constraint Areas and areas of archaeological potential (Figure 3), appropriate archaeological assessment will be required prior to the determination of a development proposal. Where significant archaeological remains are found they shall be recorded in a manner proportionate to their significance. Remains of high significance shall be preserved and protected.*
- f) *The Council will support development proposals that enable the long term preservation of heritage assets which are considered to be 'at risk' so long as the plans are considered to be sympathetic and respectful to the assets heritage significance.*
- g) *Development within the city centre primary shopping area must respect the architectural design principles of the significant elements of the post World War II reconstruction such as Broadgate and the shopping Precincts.*

Building upon the foundations set within HE1, HE2, HE3 & CC2 and in seeking to further articulate conservation parameters which may yield best outcomes the authority continues to develop supplementary design guides to sit alongside this core policy, as follows:

Other policy supporting protection of Heritage:

- DE1 – Ensuring High Quality Design Coventry Local Plan (2017)
- Design Guidelines for Development in Coventry's Ancient Arden (1995)
- Design Guidance on Shopfronts for Conservation Areas and Historic Buildings (2014)
- Coventry Station Masterplan (2014)
- Conservation Area Appraisals and Control Plans

Climate Change

Due to climate change, and the Governments pledge for the UK to reach Net Zero by 2050, there is a significant push to make buildings energy efficient, and for the City Council to reduce its carbon emissions.

Climate change can also be considered within our local policy to help homeowners achieve better insulated homes.

Covid

The impact of Covid on our everyday lives meant that our ability to visit heritage sites throughout the UK was curtailed. Many indoor venues had to shut entirely, while those outdoor attractions which often do not attract any form of entry fee were available to visit.

Furthermore, due to the fact many of the Heritage At Risk sites in Coventry were undergoing restoration resulting from the inward investment received from Coventry City of Culture, there were limited revenue losses incurred. The direct impacts of Covid onto the heritage of the city were limited. Works continued as usual, timetables stretched and the celebrations for City of Culture were pushed forward to the following year.

Recent Years

Alongside maintaining our statutory commitments to protect and enhance the historic environment by assessing applications for planning permission and listed building consent for works that affect designated and non-designated heritage assets, we also carry out our Coventry Local Plan (2016 – 2031) commitments to materially improve the historic environment and the experience of it.

Local Plan commitments from 2016 which have been completed or are underway:

- 1) In 2017 Coventry City Council transferred 22 historic sites into Historic Coventry Trusts care many of which were on the Historic England At Risk Register, in the period of time leading up to Coventry City of Culture 2021, Historic Coventry Trust in collaboration with Historic England and the City Council to undertake several restoration projects, of the 22 buildings that the City Council transferred to Historic Coventry Trust 19 buildings have either been restored or are in the process of being restored and soon will be removed from the At Risk Register.
- 2) The creation of Conservation Areas in Earlsdon and Brownhill Green, these have been completed and the associated Conservation Areas, Management Plans and Article 4 Directions were adopted by Coventry City Council on the 22nd of October 2022.
- 3) Reviewing the boundaries of the following Conservation Areas:
 - Allesley;
 - Kenilworth Road;
 - Stoke Green;
 - Greyfriars Green;
 - Ivy Farm Lane
 - High Street; and
 - Spon End.

The reviewing stage is underway, further work needs to be carried out to establish whether suggestions for change will be taken forward by cabinet.

- 4) We have nominations for Local Listing, with the inclusion of a series of artworks within City Centre South, buildings from the 19th century and more recent post war buildings, which are considered to contribute to the local character and significance of Coventry.

- 5) Charterhouse Heritage Park, proposed in policy HE3 is now also in the process of being developed, with the aim of naturalising the river valley to the south of Charterhouse Fields, opening views to the Grade II listed viaduct and recreating walkable links along the river and into Far Gosford Street, and other historic parts of the city.

Coventry is also partnering with the Warwickshire Wildlife Trust to improve the 10-mile length of the River Sherborne which runs through Coventry, aiming to restore historic structures and re-green the river corridors to promote wildlife and public uses.

Currently plans are underway for the redevelopment of Abbots Lane, this includes de-culverting a length of the river Sherborne, which connects to Nauls Park Mill Pond and will reach towards the city centre. Palmers Lane is also earmarked for regeneration and lies adjacent Heritage Action Zone of the Burges and Hale Street which saw improvements to the only Victorian in shopping street in Coventry and received a 2021 Summer Award from the Future Cities Forum and has subsequently become a National Demonstrator for Historic England's Heritage Action Zones.

The Council is currently in the process of applying for funding to Historic England for an £80,000 repair grant for the Grade II* Registered Park and Garden Stoney Road Allotments, if successful, the Council will be eligible to apply to the Heritage Lottery Funding to support the full restoration of the five Grade II Listed Summerhouses within the Stoney Road Allotments.

The Council is in process of creating two new Article 4 Directions within the city, one for the Burges and Lady Herbert Garden Conservation Area, to ensure that recent Heritage Action Zone works to improve the quality of the historic built environment and encourage regeneration of the area will be preserved. The second is going to be for the Far Gosford Street Conservation Area, and the aim is this will be supported through the local plan.

What needs updating:

- Conservation Area Control and Management Plans
- Conservation Area Boundaries
- SPD for Energy Efficiency in Historic Buildings.
- Shop Front Management Plan to include city centre shopfronts post war and Coventry Market.

Ongoing Conservation Area and Heritage Designation Evaluation

Conservation Areas Section 69 of the Planning (Listed Buildings and Conservation Areas) Act 1990 imposes a duty on local planning authorities to designate as Conservation Areas any 'areas of special architectural or historic interest the character and appearance of which it is desirable to conserve or enhance'. The Act also requires local planning authorities to review their Conservation Areas from time to time and designate extra areas where appropriate.

As with policy HE1:2, which proposed to add new Conservation Areas of Brownhill Green and Earlsdon, Conservation suggest that ongoing work is undertaken alongside established commitments, to evaluate further areas of the city which may benefit from Conservation Area status.

Recognition of the cities pioneering post war development is currently established, in part, by a number of individual buildings in the city centre which have been added to the National Heritage List, recognised for their architectural and historical significance. Ongoing assessment of if these designations deliver sufficiently robust and balanced planning assessments could be embedded in the plan, with the opportunity to introduce further controls and/or designations where this is seen as necessary to preserve historic value. Considerations of this nature could be made in the context of both existing, established designations, and indeed where non designated heritage assets may be affected by development proposals, where conservation may advise that additional designations could deliver further positive control in respect of our historic environment.